



The Determinants of the Boundary-spanning Functions of Japanese Self-initiated Expatriates in Japanese Subsidiaries in China: Individual Skills and Human Resource Management

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ABSTRACT

Self-initiated expatriates (SIEs) who work for a subsidiary of a multinational enterprise from their country of origin and hence are familiar with both countries' language and culture can be expected to act as boundary-spanners between the assigned expatriates sent from the parent country and host country nationals, and between the headquarters and the subsidiary. We develop a new model of boundary-spanning that encompasses both individual and organizational antecedents and validate the model using survey data from Japanese-affiliated companies in China. We find that familiarity with Chinese language and culture and the potential dual allegiance of SIEs contribute to enhancing their boundary-spanning behavior. We also find that relationships of trust among the parties concerned (social capital) and global career opportunities for such self-initiated expatriates (geocentric staffing) have positive influences on their dual allegiance. Finally, normative and systems integration of human resource management are associated with increasing levels of social capital and geocentric staffing.

1. Introduction

Multinational enterprises (MNEs) are seeking new human resource management (HRM) alternatives to assigning parent country nationals (PCNs) or host country nationals (HCNs) to run their foreign subsidiaries. Assigned expatriates (AEs) understand headquarters but are expensive and know little of the host context: HCNs are cheaper but understand little about headquarters objectives or systems of working. In attempts to maintain the advantages of PCNs while reducing their disadvantages (Collings and Isichei, 2018; Collings et al., 2007), MNEs have begun to use self-initiated expatriates (SIEs) (Andresen et al., 2012; Vaiman and Haslberger, 2013). If they are from the home country then they bring the multinational enterprise some of the advantages of assigned expatriates, but at much less cost; and they will know more about the host country. They are thus in a position to act as boundary-spanners.

SIEs are defined as individuals who decide on their own initiative to live and work in foreign countries (Suutari and Brewster, 2000). For MNEs, SIEs in their overseas subsidiaries are locally hired and many of them share their nationality with the organization that hires them. Thus, for example, Japanese SIEs often find themselves working for Japanese MNEs. Although they are hired as locals, and therefore are much cheaper than assigned expatriates from the parent country, such employees can be expected to act as

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